

**Time:** 4 minutes**Outcome:** Distinguish testable claims from value judgments.**Difficulty:** ●○○ Beginner

Positive vs. Normative Analysis



THE CORE IDEA

Positive analysis makes claims that evidence can test, while normative analysis applies value judgments about what should be done. The word *should* signals a policy judgment, so the statement is normative. Identify what observation could support or contradict the testable component. A positive claim is one that evidence could in principle test, even if the claim is false. This is positive because it makes a testable claim about cause and effect.



HOW TO RECOGNIZE IT

- A transit study predicts that a lower fare will increase ridership.
- This is positive because it makes a testable claim about cause and effect.
- A council member says parks should receive more funding because access is fair.
- A commissioner says the city ought to favor safer streets even if travel takes longer.
- This is positive because it is a testable cause-and-effect claim.



WATCH OUT

Do not treat positive as good, true, or politically neutral. A positive claim is one that evidence could in principle test, even if the claim is false.



WORKED EXAMPLE: POSITIVE OR NORMATIVE?

The statement 'A lower bus fare will increase ridership' is positive because ridership data can support or contradict it. The statement 'The city should lower bus fares because access is fair' is normative because it applies a value judgment. Evidence can inform both statements, but only the first is directly testable as written.



CHECK YOURSELF

Is every policy statement normative?

**READY?**

Return to the game and master this concept.